

Placement Test: Answer Key and Descriptors

Answers for Parts A and B, the section targets that decide the written band, and band descriptors for rating the writing and the speaking interview. The descriptors are aligned to the CEFR and written in plain teacher language.

Part A 50 answers

Part B 10 answers

Speaking Pre-A1-C2

Writing Pre-A1-C2

Confidential: don't hand out

QUICK-MARK STRIP • PART A

1 b • 2 c • 3 b • 4 c • 5 b • 6 b • 7 b • 8 a • 9 b • 10 a • 11 c • 12 b • 13 b •
 14 b • 15 c • 16 b • 17 b • 18 c • 19 b • 20 b • 21 c • 22 b • 23 b • 24 b • 25 a •
 26 a • 27 c • 28 a • 29 b • 30 c • 31 b • 32 a • 33 b • 34 b • 35 b • 36 b • 37 a •
 38 b • 39 b • 40 b • 41 a • 42 b • 43 a • 44 a • 45 a • 46 b • 47 a • 48 a • 49 a •
 50 b

CUT-SCORES

SECTION	ITEMS	SECURED AT	TOTAL-SCORE GUIDE (PART A)	RECOMMENDED COURSE
none / Section 1 not secured	–	–	0–12	English Foundations (A1)
Section 1 • A1	1–10	7/10	13–21	Everyday English (A2)
Section 2 • A2	11–19	6/9	22–30	Independent English (B1)
Section 3 • B1	20–28	6/9	31–38	Confident English (B2)
Section 4 • B2	29–37	6/9	39–45	Advanced English (C1)
Section 5 • C1 (± Section 6)	38–50	5/7	46–50	Mastery English (C2)

The course is decided by the highest section secured with all easier sections also secured. The total-score column is a quick cross-check only. With four options, a learner who guesses every item scores about 12, which is why the

Foundations band runs to 12. Secured Section 6 (C2) confirms Mastery English; it's also a sign the learner may be better served by a specialist course (IELTS, Business) or by C2 modules chosen to fit their goals.

PART A · ANSWERS AND EXPLANATIONS

A1 Section 1 · items 1–10

secured = 7/10

#	SENTENCE	ANS	WHY
1	Hello! My name is Ana.	b	<i>be</i> with he/she/it/name → is .
2	Where are you from?	c	<i>you</i> takes are .
3	I want an apple, please.	b	an before a vowel sound; <i>two/these</i> need a plural.
4	My sister is 25 years old.	c	Age uses be . Watch for Spanish/Portuguese/French/Arabic speakers choosing <i>has</i> .
5	Do you like coffee?	b	Present simple question with <i>you</i> → Do .
6	She works in a hospital.	b	Third person -s.
7	There are two chairs in the kitchen.	b	Plural → there are .
8	My mother's brother is my uncle .	a	Family vocabulary: uncle .
9	Look! It is raining now.	b	Happening now → present continuous is raining .
10	What time is it? — It's half past seven.	a	half past seven = 7:30.

A2 Section 2 · items 11–19

secured = 6/9

#	SENTENCE	ANS	WHY
11	I went to the doctor yesterday.	c	Past simple irregular: went .
12	Did you see the game last night?	b	Past simple question → Did + base verb.

13	My brother is taller than me.	b	Short adjective comparative → taller .
14	We are going to visit my aunt next weekend.	b	Plan → are going to + verb (needs <i>be</i>).
15	Have you ever eaten sushi?	c	Present perfect → past participle eaten .
16	I was cooking dinner when the phone rang .	b	Short action interrupting a longer one → past simple rang .
17	She has lived here since 2019.	b	Point in time → since .
18	It's the best restaurant in town.	c	Irregular superlative → best .
19	I need to make an appointment with the dentist.	b	Collocation: make an appointment .

B1 Section 3 · items 20–28

secured = 6/9

#	SENTENCE	ANS	WHY
20	If it rains tomorrow, we will stay at home.	b	First conditional → will stay .
21	I have been studying English for two years now.	c	Continuing from past to now → have been studying .
22	If I had more money, I would buy a car.	b	Second conditional → had .
23	This bridge was built in 1920.	b	Past passive → was built .
24	He asked me where I lived .	b	Reported question → statement word order: I lived .
25	I used to live in the countryside when I was a child.	a	<i>used to</i> + base verb → live .
26	The woman who lives next door is a nurse.	a	Relative pronoun for a person → who (<i>that</i> also possible, not offered).
27	I'm really looking forward to seeing you.	c	<i>look forward to</i> + -ing → to seeing .

- 28 Can you **look after** my cat while I'm on vacation? a Phrasal verb: **look after** = take care of.

B2 Section 4 · items 29–37

secured = 6/9

#	SENTENCE	ANS	WHY
29	By the time we arrived, the movie had already started .	b	Earlier past → past perfect had already started .
30	If I had known about the traffic, I would have left earlier.	c	Third conditional → would have left .
31	I wish I hadn't eaten so much last night. I feel terrible.	b	Regret about the past → <i>wish</i> + past perfect hadn't eaten .
32	She can't have left already — her coat is still here.	a	Logical deduction (impossible) → can't have .
33	He denied taking the money.	b	<i>deny</i> + -ing → taking .
34	The report must be finished by Friday.	b	Modal passive → must be finished .
35	The new rule had a big impact on small businesses.	b	Noun collocation have an impact on ; <i>affect</i> is a verb.
36	Despite the rain, the game went ahead.	b	<i>despite</i> + noun → Despite ; <i>although</i> needs a clause.
37	The meeting has been put off until next Tuesday.	a	put off = postpone.

C1 Section 5 · items 38–44

secured = 5/7

#	SENTENCE	ANS	WHY
38	Not only was he late, but he also forgot the tickets.	b	Negative adverbial → inversion was he .

39	Had I realized how difficult it was, I wouldn't have attempted it.	b	Inverted third conditional → wouldn't have attempted .
40	It's high time the city did something about housing.	b	<i>It's high time</i> + past form → did .
41	Her argument was so cogent that nobody could find a flaw in it.	a	cogent = clear, logical and convincing.
42	The findings, which were published last month, have been widely criticized.	b	Non-defining relative clause (commas) → which , never <i>that</i> .
43	The company is facing mounting criticism over its safety record.	a	Collocation mounting criticism .
44	Should you need any further information, please do not hesitate to contact me.	a	Formal inverted conditional → Should you need...

c2 Section 6 · items 45–50

secured = 4/6

#	SENTENCE	ANS	WHY
45	The minister's remarks were widely seen as an attempt to sidestep the issue.	a	sidestep an issue = avoid dealing with it.
46	Scarcely had she reached the stage when the lights went out.	b	<i>Scarcely ... when</i> → inversion had she reached .
47	His apology struck many as perfunctory — polite, but clearly insincere.	a	perfunctory = done only as a duty, without real feeling.
48	She is by no means the only one to blame for the delay.	a	Fixed pattern to blame (= responsible).
49	The plan, sound as it seemed on paper , proved unworkable in practice.	a	Concessive fronting: adjective + <i>as</i> + clause → sound as it seemed .
50	I'd sooner you didn't mention this to anyone just yet.	b	<i>I'd sooner/rather</i> + subject + past form → didn't .

PART B · READING ANSWERS

#	QUESTION	ANS	ANSWER
Text 1 · A2 email: secured at 4/5			
1	Why didn't Sam come to class on Tuesday?	b	His daughter was sick.
2	Where is Sam's new job?	c	At a supermarket.
3	When is Sam going to work?	a	In the mornings.
4	Which days is the evening class?	b	Mondays and Thursdays.
5	When can Sam meet Lina on Saturday?	c	After 2 o'clock.
Text 2 · B2 article: secured at 4/5			
6	During the trial, employees...	b	worked fewer hours for the same pay.
7	At the end of the trial, most companies...	c	decided to keep the four-day week.
8	What is one criticism mentioned in the text?	c	The companies already believed the idea would work.
9	The word <i>striking</i> (paragraph 1) is closest in meaning to...	b	surprising and impressive.
10	The writer's main point in the last paragraph is that...	b	working time has changed before and can change again.

USING PART B

Text 1 at 4–5/5 supports an A2 written band or higher. Text 2 at 4–5/5 supports B2 or higher. If Part A says B2 but Text 2 is 2/5, treat the written band as B1 and let the interview decide.

WRITING DESCRIPTORS (PART C)

Read all the tasks the learner attempted and choose the **best-fit** band: the description that matches most of the writing. Don't count errors; ask whether a reader could follow it and how much the learner can say.

BAND	WHAT THE WRITING LOOKS LIKE
Pre-A1	Can't yet complete Task 1, or copies/writes only their name. Literacy flag: do the literacy check before placing.

A1	Completes the Task 1 form with single words or short phrases. Task 2, if attempted, is 1–3 very simple sentences (<i>I work. I like coffee.</i>) with basic errors in word order and spelling.
A2	Task 2: 3–6 short sentences on daily life, linked with <i>and, but, because</i> . Present simple mostly correct; past forms attempted. Errors frequent but meaning clear.
B1	Task 2 easy; Task 3 attempted: a connected text with paragraphs or clear sequencing, simple opinions and reasons. Range of tenses; errors noticeable but rarely block meaning. May be shorter than 120 words.
B2	Task 3: clear, organized text of the required length that develops ideas with examples and linking (<i>however, as a result</i>). Good control of grammar; errors occasional and minor. Vocabulary varied, with some less common words.
C1	Task 3: well-structured, fluent text with a clear line of argument, precise vocabulary and a consistent, appropriate register. Complex sentences used naturally; errors rare.
C2	Task 3: polished, persuasive and nuanced. Wide, exact vocabulary and idiom; varied sentence structure used for effect; virtually error-free. Reads like a skilled writer.

SPEAKING DESCRIPTORS (PART D)

Rate the **highest band the learner handled comfortably**: most of the prompts in that band answered with the features below, without breakdown. If you hesitate between two bands, choose the lower and note "borderline" on the profile.

BAND	RANGE & ACCURACY	FLUENCY	INTERACTION	PRONUNCIATION
Pre-A1	Responds with gestures, single words or L1. May recognize a few words (<i>hello, yes, no</i> , numbers) but can't yet build a sentence.	Speech limited to isolated words; long silences.	Needs the interviewer to point, mime and wait.	Hard to understand beyond a few words.
A1	Short, memorized phrases and simple sentences about self and surroundings (<i>I'm from..., I like..., It's a bus</i>). Basic words for everyday things, numbers, time.	Many pauses to search for words; relies on set phrases.	Answers simple questions if they are slow and clear; rarely asks questions back.	Understandable with effort; strong L1 accent.
A2	Simple sentences joined with <i>and, but, because</i> . Talks about past events and plans using basic forms; describes home, work and routine. Frequent errors, but meaning usually clear.	Short turns; noticeable pauses, but keeps going on familiar topics.	Handles short exchanges; asks simple follow-up questions.	Generally understandable; errors sometimes cause confusion.

B1	Tells a connected story; gives opinions and reasons; uses a reasonable range of tenses, including simple conditionals. Can say most things they want to on familiar topics, with some circumlocution.	Keeps talking at length with pauses to plan and repair.	Starts, maintains and closes a conversation on familiar topics.	Clearly understandable; accent evident; occasional mispronunciation.
B2	Develops an argument with reasons, examples and a balanced view. Good grammatical control; errors don't cause misunderstanding and are often self-corrected. Varied vocabulary on general topics.	Even tempo; few noticeable long pauses.	Interacts naturally; takes turns, checks understanding, responds to challenge.	Clear, natural intonation; accent doesn't hinder.
C1	Explains complex ideas fluently and precisely, using a broad vocabulary, idiomatic expressions and complex structures. Errors rare and hard to spot.	Fluent and spontaneous; searches for words only on abstract topics.	Uses language flexibly for social and professional purposes; handles disagreement smoothly.	Varies intonation and stress to express finer meaning.
C2	Conveys fine shades of meaning with precision; uses idiom and register naturally and switches style at will. Grammar consistently accurate.	Effortless; any hesitation is for thinking, not for language.	Leads and shapes the conversation; persuades, qualifies and concedes with ease.	Pronunciation fully natural for a proficient speaker; accent irrelevant to communication.

ACCENT ISN'T LEVEL

Rate how easy the speech is to understand, not how "native" it sounds. A strong accent with clear, flexible language can still be C1. Be especially careful with learners whose pronunciation is affected by L1 sounds (for example, final consonants dropped by Vietnamese speakers, or *p/b* for Arabic speakers). Those are teaching points, not placement evidence.

WORKED EXAMPLES

LEARNER	EVIDENCE	DECISION
Learner 1	S1 9/10, S2 3/9, total 17 · Text 1 2/5 · writes 3 simple sentences · speaking A1	Written A1 = speaking A1 → Everyday English (A2)

Learner 2	Stopped after item 4 · couldn't copy a sentence · speaking A2 (fluent short stories about work)	Speaking two bands above writing: literacy gap → one course below speaking, with literacy support → English Foundations (A1) , flag for fast move-up in speaking tasks
Learner 3	S1–S3 secured, S4 7/9 (secured) · Text 2 4/5 · speaking B1	Written B2, speaking B1, one band apart → lower → Confident English (B2) ; review after 2 weeks
Learner 4	S1–S4 secured, S5 4/7, total 41 · speaking B2 · wants a university place	Written B2 = speaking B2 → Advanced English (C1) , and recommend IELTS Academic Preparation alongside